



Module 12

Goal Setting

Goals are a necessary component in effective program design. If your client has not identified a goal for which to train, you should work with the individual to come up with one. Without a specific goal, there is no focal point, and therefore intermediary goals cannot be established.

The goal of a client needs to be realistic and attainable. It is the responsibility of coaches to inform clients if they feel their goal is too far-reaching and, thus, not realistic or potentially unsafe.

If your client's goal race is months down the road, it is a good idea to choose at least one preparation race before the goal race. This is especially true for beginners, as doing a "tune-up race" will help familiarize them with the process of preparing for and participating in a running race. For more seasoned runners, tune-up events should be used for high-level training, skill training, maintaining motivation, and overall fitness/performance assessment.

For many individuals, the big-picture goal might be something other than a running event, such as weight loss, increasing cardiovascular fitness, or lowering cholesterol. For this type of client, running events are a motivating factor for a big-picture goal.

❖ OBJECTIVES

Upon completion of this module, you should have an understanding of the following areas:

- Assessing athlete potential
- Goal identification
 - Short term
 - Long term
- Advised maximum number of events per season

❖ ASSESSING POTENTIAL

For clients who have a performance-based goal, you will need to assess their potential to determine if their goal is feasible. Clients typically ask about their potential in three main areas:

1. **Personal Potential:** What is my physiological potential?
2. **Event Potential:** What is my potential for placing in a particular event?
3. **Event Preparedness:** Will I be ready to participate in a particular event?

Assessing potential can play a large role in goal selection. For example, if you have clients who want to win their age group the following year at their local running race, you will need to assess their current fitness level and how it relates to their stated goal, as well as the comparative times of the age group winners in past years.

Assessing potential is very subjective, and while one can use data to assist in this determination, at the end of the day there is a high degree of bias involved. Two coaches could assess an individual and come up with two completely different views of the client's perceived potential. The longer one has coached a client, the more accurate the individual will be in assessing a client's potential. Following are five primary things that affect the accuracy of "athlete potential" assessments:

1. Past-performance history of specific sport (e.g., running)
2. Physiological and performance testing
3. Rate of progression in training
4. Duration of working with client
5. Capacity to adapt to the training process

Following is a breakdown of each area regarding potential assessment:

Performance History in a Sport

Perhaps your client was a collegiate runner who averaged a five-minute mile for cross-country races. While the time gap between college and present time affects potential to some degree, it does give a good picture of the individual's perceived potential concerning capacity to be a fast runner.

Physiological Testing

Tests such as maximal aerobic heart rate and estimated lactate threshold can provide you with good information regarding a client's current and potential physiological capacity.

Speed of Progression in Training

As there is always room for improvement, there is no such thing as one's "potential" or "capacity," as this is a moving target. It is just a function of how close your client is to this moving target that you should attempt to assess.

When working with a deconditioned athlete or an average-conditioned athlete, the fastest rate of progress occurs in the beginning. This is natural. The better conditioned an athlete becomes, the slower the person's rate of quantitative progression.

As the name suggests, quantitative progression looks solely at the amount of improvement from a numerical standpoint, not the significance of the improvement. For example, let us say your client reduces his or her 11-minute-mile pace to 10:58. While this is an improvement, it is not very insignificant given the relatively low starting benchmark. However, if your client is currently running a 4:20 mile and reduces the time to 4:18, it is very significant as improvements made on times close to one's current physical potential are difficult to achieve and usually measured in very small increments.

Therefore, rate of progress is a good way to assess where clients are in relation to their current potential. Typically, the faster their progression, the further they are from their potential, whereas the slower they progress, typically the closer they are to their potential. While there are many reasons why a client's progress might speed up or slow down (i.e., skipping training sessions, overtraining, injury, etc.), a coach must take these factors into consideration to effectively and accurately assess the client's progress.

Duration of Client Relationship

As with any relationship, the longer two people know each other, the better they come to understand one another. The longer you work with clients and track their performance, the more historical data you will have to help predict their potential.

Capacity to Adapt to Training Process

Individuals adapt to training at different rates – remember *trainability*? If you were to take five clients at equal fitness levels and give them the exact same training program, you would most likely see five different progression rates and sets of results.

While these are five important areas to look at, there are unlimited areas that can be used to assess potential. As a coach, it is up to you to think outside the box and look for areas that you feel will most accurately assess your client's potential.

All of the aforementioned areas affect how and what goals are set. The goals should be challenging, realistic, attainable, well-rounded, and, most important, agreed upon by you and your client.

Training Log

In addition to aiding with documenting workouts, using a training log also holds substantial value for goal setting. Having clients record what they did well as well as what they feel they need improvement on during a training session or race can greatly enhance the quality of the overall training program. Areas identified as having room for improvement can translate to goals throughout the training process. For example, perhaps clients noticed that they were dropping their head at the end of their run when they got fatigued. While this is not a race-specific or fitness goal, a biomechanical improvement goal is just as important.

Sacrifice

Being able to reach a goal typically takes some form of sacrifice, whether it is getting up a half hour earlier to get a training session in, or cutting alcohol out of one's diet in an effort to lose weight.

Therefore if clients come to you with goals that you feel would require some sort of sacrifice on their part, the first thing you should do is ask them if they are seriously willing to make the sacrifice(s) to attain them. It is your job to paint a realistic picture of what you believe will be required to reach a goal versus taking on a client without explaining what you envision is going to be needed on the person's part.

❖ GOAL IDENTIFICATION

Prior to identifying a goal event, it is advised to first assess your client's fitness level, experience, biomechanical efficiency, and current training volume. Once these benchmarks have been established, based on the proper training volume progression you will be able to project by what date the client will be ready to compete in an event of a particular distance.

A goal event is different from a nongoal event. Many runners identify one or two events per year to focus on (i.e., goal event, setting a PR), while participating in other events during the year strictly with the focus of using them as part of their training.

As is discussed later in this module, the primary goal of your client might not be event-based. For example, your client's primary goal might be to lose 10 pounds, and running is the primary means to exercise and lose weight. However, even in these cases, a goal event should be identified as a focal point of the training process.

IDENTIFY GOAL EVENT

The date of the goal event as well as any other preparation or training events are the genesis for assessing the distance and training time facets of the program.

If your client already has a goal event in mind or has signed up for an event, you will need to assess if the person will be properly prepared for the event given current level of conditioning and training volume.

The number of goal events per year is based on how many times an athlete can properly peak for an event. As noted previously, all goal events should be challenging, but attainable.

Maximum Goal Events per Season

The training volume and number of events per session will vary greatly between novice and experienced runners.

The following guidelines outlining the limit of goal events are event-distance specific. More than likely, a program will be made up of different-length events (including goal and preparatory events).

Even if runners have past running experience, if they have not run and/or done any form of exercise in the past 12 months, they should be considered *novices*. Therefore be advised of the following UESCA definitions of **novice** and **experienced** runners:

Novice: No running experience, someone who has not run in the past year, someone who is deconditioned.

Experienced: Consistently ran during the prior 12 months or more.

Be advised that novice runners who have past running experience but have not run in the past 12 months will likely progress faster than novice runners who have no experience running.

NOVICE RUNNERS

It is advisable to limit your client who is new to running to three 10K or five 5K events per season. It is not recommended for first-year runners to undertake a half or full marathon, regardless of their fitness level. Do novice runners participate in marathons? Yes. Is it advised? No.

As the cardiovascular system typically adapts to training faster than the musculoskeletal system, running high mileage during the first year of training will likely put a runner at an increased chance for injury.

- If your client's goal is a 10K event, the individual should start with a 5K. This is not based solely on fitness level but also takes into consideration experience. Just as a physical training program has a proper rate of progression, so does the selection of races.
- If it is your client's first year competing, do not focus on goal times. Instead, put the focus on finishing races and feeling good and uninjured!

- It is advisable when working with new runners to select an event that is geographically close to home and involves terrain and environmental factors (high altitude, extreme heat) that are not too challenging. If it is your client's first race, a 5K is advised.

EXPERIENCED RUNNERS

If your client wants to target more than one goal event for the season, it is advisable to limit the target events to:

Marathon: 2

Half Marathon: 3

10K: 4

5K: 5

These goal-event guidelines assume that you will be working with your client for the full calendar year. The aforementioned events refer only to goal events, not preparation events.

Regardless if an event is a goal or training race, following are the **maximum** number of events that should be undertaken per year by an experienced runner:

- **Marathon: 3**
- **Half Marathon: 4**

This is largely based on the training program duration, potential for injury, and ability to properly recover.

Following are several goal-event scenarios that could be feasible for your experienced clients, assuming they have a solid base fitness level:

- 1 marathon, 2 half marathons
- 2 marathons, 1 half marathon
- 3 half marathons

Identify Preparation (Tune-Up) Events

Once you have established that a client's goal event(s) is feasible based at the person's current level of fitness and training volume, you will want to plot a preparation event or events. To do this, select events that are the appropriate distance in respect to where the client is in the training program. There should always be at least one preparation event. As noted earlier, for new runners the focus of preparation events is to gain experience, whereas for experienced runners, the focus shifts to high-intensity training, assessing current fitness, and performance levels.

Some coaches and athletes denote events by letters:

- **“A” event** = goal event
- **“B” event** = important preparatory event
- **“C” event** = training or minor event

Quantitative Goals

Aside from providing experience, goals should be quantitative and measureable. Common goals are:

- Race or training times
- Performance testing (e.g., heart rate, lactate)
- Race placing
- Weight or body fat loss/gain
- Weight or repetitions for strength-training assessments
- Range of motion for flexibility-based assessments
- Reduction or elimination of illness/disease/pain (e.g., high blood pressure, diabetes, high cholesterol, lower-back pain)
- RPE

While not as quantitative, if assessed using a 10-point scale (0 being low, 10 being high) initially and for future assessments, the following areas can be analyzed quantitatively.

- Stress
- Energy level
- Productivity

- Sleep

From a goal-event standpoint, establishing quantitative goals throughout the season, such as performance testing and training/preparation race times, assists greatly in determining if your client is on track. Additionally, these midseason goals help clients to stay motivated and keep their head in the game.

Goals need to be realistic. For example, if your client is currently averaging a nine-minute-mile pace for a 10K, it is highly unlikely the person will be able to average a seven-minute mile in one month's time. This is an example of a poorly established goal. Properly established, quantitative goals can be derived from some or all of the following:

1. Past and current testing data (if applicable)
2. Initial and current assessments
3. Client's rate of progression

By establishing goals with your clients, you will be able to ascertain what motivates them. Understanding this is critical to developing a program that is engaging as well as fulfilling for a client.

LONG-/SHORT-TERM GOALS

What constitutes long- and short-term goals is subjective. However, you must be aware that your client might be targeting a goal further out than one year, which may or may not be event specific. For example, your client may have the goal to qualify for the Boston Marathon in two years, or perhaps you are working with a very talented client whose goal is to participate in the Olympic Trials in three years. These are all examples of long-term goals that are more than 12 months away.

Conversely, whether short-term goals are weekly, biweekly, or monthly, they are important to maintain motivation and structure.

❖ SUMMARY

- Assessing potential is an important variable in accurately identifying a client's goals.
- There are five primary ways to address potential:
 - Past-performance history of specific sport (e.g., running)
 - Physiological and performance testing
 - Rate of progression in training
 - Duration of working with client
 - Capacity to adapt to training process
- Not all goals are event specific.
- Goals should be quantitative in nature, with the exception of training youth clients, as the focus should be having fun.
- Identify goal and preparation events.
- Goals should be short and long term.
- Training logs assist with goal setting.
- New runners, regardless of their physical condition, should not sign up for a marathon in their first year of training.